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The King who would be Man: the Gender Roles of the Warrior King in Early Mughal History

ALI ANOOSHAHR

There has appeared a new trend in recent scholarship on the early modern Islamic world that analyzes the role of gender and sexuality in society and culture. Ruby Lal and Rosalind O'Hanlon have investigated women and gender roles in the sixteenth-century Mughal harem and the broader imperial court respectively.¹ Mehmed Kalpaklı, Walter Andrews, and Khaled El-Rouayheb have studied the nature or the implications of sexual relationship among men in Istanbul as well as the Arab provinces of the Ottoman Empire.² Kathryn Babayan and Afsaneh Najmabadi have read Safavid and Qajar literature and visual arts through the lens of gender and power politics.³ Together these scholars have successfully highlighted the relevance of this methodology particularly in its application to the narrative sources that comprise the bulk of our documentations for the period (except for the Ottoman case of course), and it is to subject to such an approach a brief, but crucial, period in early Mughal history and historiography that the present article now proceeds.

Not long after the founder of the Mughal Empire Babur died in 1530, his son Humayun entirely lost the kingdom he had recently inherited. In the spring of 1540, the Afghans of South Asia regrouped under the formidable Sher Shah of the Sur clan and defeated the Mughal forces in two key battles. Crushed and abandoned, the desperate Humayun had to trek across north India and Afghanistan into Safavid domains, with whose help the prince was able to return several years later and only managed to restore the dynasty in Hindustan in 1555. Many reasons are given in order to account for Humayun's failure – the fact that he had to share the kingdom with his uncooperative brothers, the unusual ability of his arch-nemesis, as well as a number of mistakes on his own part.⁴ All these factors are no doubt

¹Ruby Lal, *Domesticity and Power in the Early Mughal World* (Cambridge, 2005). Rosalind O'Hanlon, "Manliness and Imperial Service in Mughal North India", *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient*, vol. 42, No. 1 (1999), pp. 47–93. Especially O'Hanlon. "kingdom, household and body: history, gender and imperial service under Akbar", *Modern Asian Studies*, Vol. 41, No. 5 (2007), pp. 889–923.

²Walter G. Andrews and Mehmet Kalpaklı, *The Age of Beloveds: love and the beloved in Early-Modern Ottoman and European Culture and Society*, (Durham, 2005). Khaled El-Rouayheb, *Before Homosexuality in the Arab-Islamic World, 1500–1800*, (Chicago, 2005).

³Kathryn Babayan, *Mystics, Monarchs and Messiahs: Cultural Landscapes of Early Modern Iran*, (Cambridge, 2002). Afsaneh Najmabadi, *Women with mustaches and men without beards: gender and sexual anxieties of Iranian modernity*, (Berkeley, 2005).

⁴See for example J. F. Richards, *The Mughal Empire*, (Cambridge, 1993), pp. 9–10. The fullest accounts of these events are by William Erskine, *History of India: Under the First Two Sovereigns of the House of Taimur, Baber and Humayun* (reprint New York, 1972), and Ishawan Prasad, *The Life and Times of Humayun* (Bombay, 1956). The only full account of Kamran is the brief but good monograph of Iqtidar Alam Khan, *Mirza Kamran: A Biographical Study*

important. Nevertheless, when reading the sources from these early years of the Mughal Empire one cannot help but notice the stark contrast between Babur and Humayun, not simply in military matters (after all Babur too made plenty of errors), but in the ability of the father to control and manipulate language and the son's utter helplessness in this regard, at least early on in his life. Perhaps it was no coincidence that Humayun, unlike his imperial forerunner, neglected to write his own memoirs, nor did he commission historians to chronicle his life, as did his successor Akbar.⁵

Babur had inherited a sophisticated Timurid culture of political manipulation of visual and literary arts,⁶ and had gained invaluable experience by years of fighting and losing, living in an unpredictable world full of possibilities. His fate was not predetermined. Rather he was the author of his own life, literally. He inscribed himself on paper and on the leaves of the 'book of the world' in order to ensure success. Humayun on the other hand lived in an overly determined universe, whose course he would try to guess at by augury or astrology, and with whose unalterable stability he would try to transfix the environment around him.⁷ Humayun appears to have been much less interested in inter-human communication, and the rigidity and inflexibility with which he believed all signs to be endowed, made it much more difficult for him to manipulate by writing people's perception of him.⁸

The results were disastrous. In what follows, it will be argued that Humayun's indifference or failure to realise the importance of exerting direct control over his image had dire consequences. Chroniclers such as Bayazid Bayat and Jawhar (men of relatively low military rank in Humayun's camp) consistently compared the emperor with his rivals, including his brother Kamran and his Afghan enemy Sher Shah, in such a way as to suggest that Humayun had fallen short specifically in fulfilling gender roles appropriate to a warrior king, particularly regarding the categories of violence (exerting violence, withstanding violence or hardship in

(Aligarh, 1964). The most recent treatment of Sher Shah's reign from the perspective of Afghan chroniclers is by Raziuddin Aquil, *Sufism, Culture, and Politics: Afghans and Islam in Medieval North India* (Delhi, 2007).

⁵The sole exception, being a text commissioned by Humayun and composed by the historian Khvandamir, dating from the early years of his reign, and being more a catalogue of his regulations, curious toys, and his wardrobe, than a continuous narrative.

⁶Thomas W. Lentz and Glen D. Lowry, *Timur and the Princely Vision: Persian Art and Culture in the Fifteenth Century* (Los Angeles, 1989).

⁷Humayun's passion for organising his immediate surrounding and attaching it to natural cycles and astrological markers is informed by the same mentality. Khvandamir tells us that after becoming king, Humayun divided "all the people in his kingdom" into three classes, each class subdivided into twelve ranks: people of the state (soldiers and notables), men of fortune (scholars), and people of pleasure (musicians, singers, etc). The names of each group had been suggested to him by an omen he had taken while riding one day. In addition, court ceremony was restricted to each group on specific days of the week in association with the relevant stars (so, Saturday and Thursday, associated with Saturn and Jupiter respectively, were set aside for the people of fortune, Tuesday and Sunday, associated with Mars and the Sun, were restricted for the people of the state). Each day had its own particular colour according to which the king and his servants would dress. Moreover, the business of each day had been decided upon before hand by its planetary determinant. So for example, on Tuesdays (Mars) the court would dress in red, the soldiers would be invited, and sentencing on capital cases would be read out. Ghiyas al-Din Khvandamir, *Qanun-i Humayuni*, ed. Hidayat Hosain, (Calcutta, 1940), pp. 25–28.

⁸Jawhar writes that on his return from the Safavid domain and start of his campaign to retake India, one day in 1548 Humayun while feeding a white cock had said to himself, "if it is the will of fortune to favour me, the cock will mount upon my shoulder and evince his delight". The cock does so, convincing the emperor that he is on the right path. See Jawhar, *Tezkereh al-Vakiat or, Private Memoirs of the Moghul Emperor Humayun*, tr. Charles Stewart (reprint New Delhi, 1970). Or again, when in Khwandamir we get one of earliest glimpses of the prince, we see him trotting around on the road between Kabul and Qandahar, where it occurs to him to "ask the names of three persons whom he may meet and take an omen from it". He does so and the well-sounding names that he hears become the nomenclature by which he later subdivides and designates the members of his court.

general and knowing the appropriate time for withholding violence) and politics of sexuality (self-control, marriage, and conquest).

The analysis will begin with a long passage from the memoirs of the Mughal soldier Bayazid Bayat, a passage that embodies well all the issues alluded to above. The scene is extracted from Bayazid's narrative of the battle of Qipchaq (1550) where Humayun's brother Kamran still managed to free himself from the clutches of his opponent in spite of major disadvantages. It reads as follows:

At this time, Mirza Kamran went up to the top of a ridge that overlooked the scene below. The Mirza's women and daughters also wrapped turbans around their heads and came out with the men. The matchlock-men at the front [of Humayun's forces] hadn't loaded their weapons. Most of them were Mirza Kamran's former gunners who had joined his majesty [Humayun] at Kabul. Once the Mirza reached the top of the ridge, he shot two or three rounds of arrows and wounded most of the king's men and horses who were in the wings. Meanwhile, His Majesty turned to Mast Ali Qurchi and said, "You're a brave young man. Why are you standing here at a time like this?" That wretch answered, "Let whoever you gave those fine armors to ride out!" Qasim Husayn was positioned on the other side of the river with good troops. He had plenty of room to charge the Mirza's vanguard, but he didn't apply himself and didn't charge. No other commander had the kind of troops who could take on the Mirza. When the Mirza saw the pathetic weakness (*zabūnī*) of his majesty's army, he stormed down the slope and attacked the standards. The standard-bearers couldn't resist him. They turned around and ran with lowered standards. Qasim Husayn Khan too turned back and fled with the same troops who had been standing around him. His majesty also escaped with the men and came to the valley through which the army had marched initially.⁹

The first thing to note is that Kamran fights but Humayun does not. While the Mirza climbs the ridge, shoots arrows, and charges at the standard-bearers, the king gives orders to others without personally involving himself in the fray. Now, Bayazid suggests that those who did not fight Kamran were either able but refused to do so or otherwise simply lacked the necessary strength. They were no match for him, we are told. One can infer then that soldiers such as the author of this episode must have thought Humayun was a more frail prince than Kamran, since he was not fighting but obviously did not lack the will or motivation to fight. It should come as no surprise that this distinction could have gendered, even sexual, undertones. Humayun's own words in the passage bear this out. He describes Mast Ali Qurchi's valour in terms of "manliness" (*javānmardī*). In turn Humayun's apparent lack of courage might be considered unmanly. Incidentally, it should be noted here that "unmanly" need not imply effeminacy, because, unlike modern perceptions, the strict binary opposites of male/female do not occur exclusively in the texts of these periods (though I shall return to this point when discussing the cross-dressing of Kamran's women folk). Rather, the masculine attributes of soldiers would have included aggressiveness and bravery, some sense of mercy, and the ability to bear with pain and hardship. Against these we encounter in the "unmanly" a kind of pathetic weakness (*zabūnī*) which may be manifested in the inability to exact revenge as well as a love for fineries and comfort. In the martial environment of power politics in the first half of the sixteenth century (a carry-over from the military patronage

⁹Bayazid Bayat, *Tazkira-i Humayun va Akbar*, ed. Hidayat Hosein (Calcutta, 1941), pp. 128–129.

system of the previous centuries), kings were expected to possess the characteristics of the former. And yet consistently, we find Humayun described as a lover of luxury who fights much less than his adversaries and perhaps forgives too much. It should be clear why, time and again, Kamran was able to muster so much support among the soldiers in the dynastic tug-of-war with his brother. For one (and there are of course many more military, social, and political reasons), he had fulfilled the gender roles of the warrior king.

That bravery and aggression were viewed as similar qualities present in a masculine warrior might seem self-evident, though supporting examples do not occur as frequently as one might expect. Perhaps it was taken for granted by the sources. Bayazid does indeed praise the Safavid supporters of Humayun in the battle of Qandahar for “undertaking several manly swordfights against the infantrymen of the fort, many of whom [the defenders] were thrashed”.¹⁰ Suja, the author of the near-contemporary Rajasthani epic *Chhanda Rau Jetsai Rau* expresses the sentiment by comparing belligerent warriors to ferocious beasts of prey such as boars or tigers.¹¹ Some years earlier, Babur had regularly used the adjective ‘manly’ (*mardāna*) to describe brave commanders particularly as they had “soundly struck down” (*yakhshī bastī*) their foes.¹² Thus in one sense, to be manly meant to be able to inflict violence on one’s enemy.

But at the same time it was equally important as a sign of masculinity to be able to tolerate pain and hardship. It is in this sense that Bayazid commends a number of Humayun’s emirs for showing “utmost manliness and leadership” by fighting while bearing five or six injuries each inflicted by swords and maces.¹³ The Afghan historian Abdullah, who wrote the *Tarikh-i Davudi*, describes a march of Sher Shah in the maddening summer heat of Bengal favourably where Sher Shah and his men dressed in full armour could tolerate with cheerful aspects the hardships of their journey.¹⁴ In this case Abdullah explicitly credits Sher Shah’s willingness to set the example of endurance for his men. One might add here the famous episode in the *Baburnama* when, during a snowstorm on a march to Kabul, Babur refuses to take shelter in the comfort (*farāghat*) of a warm cave along with his commanders but rather sleeps in the snow side by side with his soldiers to prove his manliness (*muruvvatliq*) and comradeship (*hamjahatliq*).¹⁵ In sum, a second important attribute of masculinity was the ability of tolerate pain and hardship, and in this, it was especially important for the leader to act as the model, embodying an ultimate manliness expressed out of one’s free choice and not necessity.

Finally, in addition to possessing the gift for committing or withstanding violence, the male warrior could be expected to withhold it against a helpless counterpart out of clemency and magnanimity. It was in this sense that Babur’s daughter Gulbadan remembered her father’s forgiveness of the subdued but formerly rebellious Khusraw Shah, which to her betokened the signs of his manliness (*mardī* and *muruvvat*).¹⁶ Similarly, Gulbadan recalled the hospitality offered by the Safavid king Shah Tahmasp to the exiled Humayun as a sign of the shah’s *muruvvat*.¹⁷ Magnanimity and forgiveness were therefore a third aspect of masculinity,

¹⁰ Bayazid, *Tazkira*, p. 42.

¹¹ Bithu Suja, *Chhanda Rau Jetsai Rau*, tr. Rajvi Amar Singh (Bikaner, 1986), pp. 93 & 128.

¹² For example, Babur *Baburnama*, 3 volumes, ed. and tr. by W. M. Thackston (Cambridge, 1993), p. 14a.

¹³ Bayazid, *Tazkira*, pp. 198–199.

¹⁴ Abdullah *Tarikh-i Da’udi*, (Aligarh, 1954), p. 144.

¹⁵ Babur 194b.

¹⁶ Gulbadan Begam Humayun’ *namah*, ed. and trans. by Annette S. Beveridge, (reprint, Delhi, 1972), p. 5.

¹⁷ Gulbadan p. 69.

at least for warriors. It is worth noting that all three gender roles for fighting men outlined above involve an orientation towards violence or pain, whether in inflicting it, bearing it, or withholding it.

Now, when one compares the actions of the two brothers and rivals Humayun and Kamran, one is struck by how much Kamran excelled in performing the appropriate gender roles while his brother did not. Even in his eventual defeat and punishment (he was blinded), Kamran was remembered by the memoirists Bayazid and Jawhar, both loyal soldiers in Humayun's camp, as the epitome of these male virtues. Bayazid recalls the order of Humayun to blind Kamran with a great deal of respect for the victim. He remembered how Kamran had begun throwing punches at the men commissioned with the blinding, because he had thought they had come to execute him.¹⁸ When he discovered their charge he submitted to it with such self-control that Humayun's men returned and "proclaimed the utmost bravery that they witnessed in the Mirza".¹⁹ Jawhar, who personally took part in the blinding, tells us that Kamran did not utter a sound as his eyes were poked fifty times with the needle and only complained at one of the men who had sat on his knees. Twice in this brief passage did Jawhar qualify Kamran's resilience with the adjective "manly" (*mardāna*).²⁰ Thus in the accounts of both Jawhar and Bayazid, we see the image of Kamran as a tireless warrior who could bring down ruin on his enemies but could put up with pain while maintaining total poise. What Kamran apparently lacked in mercy was less of a slight against his manliness since, as it will be shortly argued, too much clemency could be considered a sign of weakness. This is very much Humayun's problem who is described as in many respects the opposite of Kamran.

Humayun fails to regularly take the field himself (as compared to Kamran, Babur, or even Sher Shah), and often he seemed to contemporaries as one who was too interested in comfort and luxury. Both Gulbadan and the historian Khvandamir were with Humayun in his first days of reign, and they both describe his lavish coronation feasts attended by "youths, pretty girls, and beautiful women".²¹ These activities need not have necessarily merited censure had they not been considered to have had a softening effect on the warrior king. One starts to have suspicions regarding Humayun when one of his courtiers calls him "a delicate king" (*pādshāhi latīf*).²² Or when during a march plagued by cold and hunger, Bayazid recalls how Humayun had asked one of his men to sit down and "recite" so that Humayun could put his head on the man's lap and fall asleep.²³ This is precisely the opposite behaviour of Sher Shah or Babur who were seen as always participating in events shoulder to shoulder with their men and comrades and bearing their hardship with exemplary fortitude. No wonder that later Afghan historians attribute a telling statement to Sher Shah who predicts victory over Humayun and scorns him as a "pleasure-seeking (*'ayyāsh*) and comfort-loving (*farāghat dūst*) king".²⁴

Avoidance of battle and hardship due to an unmanly and softening way of life could prejudice people against a king even as he was a bit overgenerous in clemency and

¹⁸ Bayazid, p. 156.f.

¹⁹ Bayazid, p. 157.

²⁰ Jawhar, quoted in the Urdu introduction to M. Mahfuz-ul Haq's *The Persian Diwan of Kamran*, (son of Babur Padshah) edited from the unique manuscript in Patna by kāmran. (Calcutta, 1929) p. 33.

²¹ Gulbadan, p. 31.

²² Bayazid, p. 63.

²³ Bayazid, p. 123.

²⁴ Abdullah p. 121, Ahmad Yadgar, *Tārikha-i-Shahi*. ed. M. Hidayat Hosain. (Calcutta, 1939), p. 185.

magnanimity. One is struck by how many times Humayun forgives Kamran after getting the upper hand on him. But the inability to exact revenge on one's enemy could have a deteriorating effect on one's image. The clearest example of this problem is stated by the Afghan historian Ahmad Yadgar. While writing about the early days of the Lodi dynasty and Sultan Bahlul's usurpation of the throne from his rival 'Ala al-Din, Ahmad Yadgar declared the latter simply unfit to rule because, "'Ala al-Din was ill-favoured by a pathetic weakness [*zabūn bakht*], had a serene countenance and nature, and possessed a bashful constitution. He had nothing to do with kingship".²⁵ The implication is of course that kings ought to be energetic and audacious. The author especially resented how the prince's ill-favoured and pathetic weakness enfeebled his resolve for revenge (*intiqām*). Thus, Humayun's repeated pardon of Kamran would eventually be held against him. The frankest denunciation occurs in Gulbadan's memoirs where she recalled numerous commanders telling the king to choose between his clemency towards his brother and kingship: "If you desire the goodwill of your brother, then give up kingship. If you wish to be a king, give up brotherhood".²⁶ Thus, regarding the three male virtues of warriors outlined above, viz. aggression, fortitude, and clemency, Kamran best embodied the first two, while Humayun only managed to exceed in the third which in turn cast a further shadow on his masculinity (similar to 'Ala al-Din above).

But being unmanly was not necessarily the same as being "effeminate" in this period. What exactly characterised the emasculate? In modern times the binary opposite pairs of active/passive (assuming a sexual encounter between two men) are often used to distinguish the "masculine" and "unmanly" males. While there are some hints suggesting this in the sources, passivity is too inadequate a concept for describing a man who fails in his male gender roles. Essentially what Humayun does is to act as if he were still in a stage of immaturity. He loses the power of the adult male. This is evidenced in Humayun's being described as the beloved in a love relationship (even if poetically and fictively), but also in his engagement in sexuality for the sake of pleasure but not for its functional utility (in the case of a king these would be siring a male offspring and improving one's political position). As we shall see Humayun is not very successful in the politics of sexuality.

To begin, Bayazid provides two examples in which Humayun is described as a beloved by another male – an occurrence that may appear at first perfectly innocuous. For example, when Humayun fled in disgrace from India and Afghanistan to the Safavid domains, Shah Tahmasp sent a document demanding from his officials the performance of all the requirements of royal hospitality towards the exiled Mughal prince. In this letter, as reproduced in Bayazid's history, the Shah at one point compares Humayun to a beloved for whose company the Shah has been intently desirous. Some pages later Tahmasp describes Humayun as a "noble and colourful flower from the flowerbed of kingship and delicacy, moonfaced and angelic". Whatever Shah Tahmasp's intentions may have been, one can safely state that such qualifiers were quite similar to the ones used by the likes of Sher Shah in mocking Humayun. But, even Kamran had on a few occasions assumed a position towards his brother that was very similar to that of Shah Tahmasp. For example, Bayazid tells us that after being blinded by Humayun, Kamran compared his situation to a lover who has been wounded by his

²⁵ Ahmad Yadgar, p. 5.

²⁶ Gulbadan, p. 95.

haughty beloved.²⁷ But even early on, when Humayun had ascended the throne and given the governorship of certain provinces to Kamran, the latter had sent the new Mughal emperor some presents and an ode in which Humayun had been compared to the archetypal beloved of Persian, Arabic, and Turkish poetry Layli and Kamran to the lover Majnun.²⁸ To be described as a beautiful and delicate flower, or simply a beloved, by another king did certainly entail a manipulation of gender roles. However, modern anachronisms can severely mar our understanding of sixteenth-century love relationships between males, and so a brief detour must be undertaken.

In spite of its continuous usage by prominent scholars of the field,²⁹ we know by now that modern terms such as bisexual or homosexual are completely inappropriate for describing pre-modern sexuality. The concepts simply did not exist. In general, while an older man's love for a youth was perfectly acceptable, sexual contact, and particularly sodomy, was condemned. The famous case of Babur who openly expressed his love for a camp boy (leading to Babur's spiritual madness without any sexual contact with the boy) and his simultaneous censuring of sexual relations between some Timurid princes and certain youths are well known.³⁰ But how would such relationships translate into the realm of political power? Najmabadi tells us that being the beloved (the role in which Humayun was placed above) was nothing shameful, whereas El-Rouhayeb claims that it was since it would imply that the beloved was the "passive" member in such a pairing.³¹ In the Indo-Persian and Central Asian sources, at least among the fighting men (headed by the king) certain social hierarchies and restrictions figured significantly into the equation. Let us take the example of Babur's uncle Mahmud Mirza whom Babur reviles for his vices ("*fisq*") among which was his sexual predation towards young men. "He kept a lot of catamites ("*chuhra*"), and in his realm whenever there was a comely, beardless youth ("*amrad*"), he did everything he could to turn him into a catamite".³² Here, it is clear that the transition from the *amrad* to *chuhra* was a deplorable one, but at least as much for the older male (Mahmud Mirza) as for the younger. In other words, the passive vs. active distinction seems to not apply here. But of course there is another element to Mahmud's Mirza's personification that seems to have been overlooked by scholarship. Mahmud Mirza embodied a potential threat towards Babur himself. Militarily, Babur recounts that after his father's death in June of 1494, his two uncles led a two-pronged attack on their late brother's territory. Babur recounts that his older uncle Ahmad Mirza (whom Babur describes as an upright man) was eventually convinced to leave his nephew and turned back towards his own holdings, dying along the way due to an illness.³³ Mahmud Mirza on the other hand had continued to pose a threat and had captured the fortress of Akhsi which had been left in charge of Babur's younger brother

²⁷ Bayazid p. 159.

²⁸ *The Persian Diwan of Kamran*, p. 3. For more on the political background see also Mahfuz-ul Haq's English introduction, p. 3 and footnote 15.

²⁹ McChesney "bisexual" see for instance R. D. McChesney's characterisation of Babur as "bisexual", R. D. McChesney, "Review of *The Garden of Eight Paradises* by Stephan Dale", *Iranian Studies* Vol. 39, No. 3 (2006), p. 441.

³⁰ O'Hanlon, "Kingdom, household and body" p. 30.

³¹ Najmabadi, p. 23; El-Rauhayeb, pp. 23 and 153.

³² Babur p. 25b.

³³ Babur p. 18a.

Jahangir Mirza, and then become lord of Samarkand the Timurid capital.³⁴ Now, coupled with this threat of Babur's political subjugation by his uncle was the possibility of a sexual dominance as well. For Babur clearly states that Mahmud Mirza's love for beardless youths was not checked by any social taboos and even extended to his own family. We are told that Mahmud Mirza "Turned his sons' . . . milk-brothers into catamites. He even demanded the service of his own milk-brothers' sons".³⁵ Milk-brothers and sisters were individuals who had shared the same wet-nurse and were considered as brothers and sisters in a number of social and legal arenas (for instance, they were forbidden to marry). Babur's uncle's hounding of his own milk-brothers' sons practically amounted to the pursuit of his own nephews, an idea that the twelve-year old Babur had clearly found rather troubling. Here we get a glimpse of the social implications of sexual relations between older and younger men from the perspective of a potential victim. As a king as well as a family member, Babur seems to have considered it parallel to the threat of political domination and resented it.

But in addition to sexual advances, even the expression of non-sexual love towards kings appears to have been blameworthy in the eyes of some. We know for example, that love of an older men for a youth would have been considered acceptable, even commendable, if it fell within the ritual of gazing on beauty which would in turn sublimate the lover towards the ultimate love of God. For example, Babur himself openly proclaims his love for the camp boy which in turn had led to his walking in ecstasy in alleyways and fields, suggesting his succumbing to a divine (Sufi) madness that such passions should have aroused in him. And yet, this same Babur goes out of his way to criticise the poet Hilali for having composed a book in which a young prince had been described as a beloved by a Sufi mendicant.

When poets of *masnavis* [rhymed couplets] in former times wrote on love, they gave the attributes of the lover to a man and those of the beloved to a woman. Hilali, on the other hand, has made a dervish the lover and a king the beloved, a shameless strumpet in fact. It is really an affront that, in the interest of his poem, [Hilali] describes a young man – and a king at that – as a brazen woman or prostitute.³⁶

It is a sudden shift of tone for Babur to rebuke Hilali for seemingly doing what he himself had done a few pages before. But on closer inspection, the differences between the two become more apparent. Babur had described a camp boy, a social inferior as a beloved. Hilali however had transgressed a social hierarchy. The transgression of status has secondary implication of describing the male king in the language previously reserved for women. Finally, combining the contraventions of gender and status, the king had been described a prostitute – a woman of the lowest social status. We can see here that relegating young royals to the position of the beloved, even in a non-sexual and avowedly mystical setting (though significantly involving an impudent usage of sexual language), could be considered inappropriate.

The only places, it seems, where one could appropriately praise a young king as a beloved, would have been in cases where the king stood for the divinity. Take the case of the young

³⁴Babur pp. 23a–24a.

³⁵Babur p. 25b.

³⁶Babur p. 181b.

Lodi Sultan Sikandar for example. Sixteenth and early seventeenth-century Indo-Persian histories record an anecdote about him and an old Sufi master who had fallen in love with him. It exists in various similar versions, and one runs as follows:

Shaykh Hasan fell in love with Sultan Sikandar's beautiful face, and that the shaykh was one of the perfect men of his age. One day in winter the prince was sitting in his private quarters, and the shaykh felt the urge to gaze at him. Due to the purity of nature that men of God possess, the shaykh was able to appear in the prince's presence where even the wind could not enter directly. Sultan Sikandar was greatly amazed at this. He said, "Shaykh Hasan, how did you get in here with all those guards posted at the doors?" The shaykh replied, "You know better how I've come here and why". "You claim you're in love with me?" asked the prince. "I simply cannot help it", retorted the shaykh. The sultan said, "come closer", and the shaykh came closer. A bed of hot coals was before the sultan. He grabbed the back of the shaykh's neck, shoved his face to the fire, and pressed down on his neck. Shaykh Hasan let his head and face be put on those smoldering coals without moving in the slightest. A long time passed in this way. Suddenly Mubarak Khan Lawhani arrived. When he saw this strange spectacle, he asked the sultan, "Who is this person?" Sultan Sikandar said that it was Shaykh Hasan. Mubarak Khan exclaimed, "What are you doing? Have you no fear of God? This fire cannot damage Shaykh Hasan. It is you yourself who should fear harm from this act". But the sultan protested, "He claims he's in love with me". Mubarak Khan replied, "You should be grateful that such an illustrious man has noticed you. If you want the fortune of both worlds, serve him well". He lifted the prince's hand from the shaykh's neck, and they saw that the scorching fire had not affected the shaykh's face and beard in the least. In spite of this, the sultan commanded his men to shackle the shaykh in chains and throw him into a dungeon.³⁷

On one level, the story is about the miraculous powers of the shaykh and his ability to defy human limitations when in love. But clearly, Sultan Sikandar's distrust of the whole thing is quite real and his reaction very severe. It is true that the shaykh escapes both punishments (the next day, we are told, he was found dancing in the bazaar). But nevertheless the story assumes that some sort of outraged response from the young prince would be perfectly natural. How then does the story reconcile this apparent breach of etiquette (i.e. describing a young prince as the object of a non-sexual love relationship)? By making Sultan Sikandar divine. There is an episode that appears in all these early Afghan histories (Yadgar, Mushtaqi, and Abdullah) where the Sultan is described as a mysterious horseman who brings justice to those who are wronged and even brings a dead man to life. It is thus only in such situations, when the king is virtually divine, that the earthly love of an older man towards a younger boy (intended as the gateway to loving God) can be extended to princes. This is precisely how Humayun is eulogised by poets in the only text commissioned by him in the early days of his reign. Khvandamir the author of the *Qanun-i Humayuni* quoted a number of verses composed by a panegyrist in honour of the young king that did describe him as a beloved but wrapped up the poem by celebrating his near divinity. "Why do people's eyes", so it runs, "not have the power to bear looking at him, if not because divine light shines out of his forehead?"³⁸ To return then to our original problem, namely Humayun's depiction as the beloved by Shah Tahmasp and Kamran, the resulting effect is no compliment to the

³⁷ Abdullah pp. 27–28.

³⁸ Khvandamir p. 29.

king since he is described or perceived as divine neither by the two royals nor by Bayazid, the author of the text in which the verses occur. These comparisons then contributed to Humayun's presentation as unmanly.

"Unmanliness" as immaturity, as a kind of being unripe as contrasted to the adult male, had further manifestations beyond one's portrayal as the male beloved. It extended to one's sexuality as well. It is precisely here that we can see how irrelevant modern categories of sexuality are in this period. Unmanly does not mean effeminate, nor does it extend to sexual preference for men. The difference between the masculine and the not-yet-masculine lies in the function, not the direction towards a particular gender, of sexuality.³⁹ First and foremost, the adult male was expected to use sexuality for social gain (in terms of gaining offspring or political alliances), whereas the unmanly man engaged in it mainly for pleasure. In addition to this there existed a further nuance of successful sexual prowess for men, which was generally condemn by the sources of the period, and yet, one can find evidence not far beneath the surface, that, at least among some soldiers, wife-stealing was looked upon favourably.

But let us begin with sexuality for pleasure. It was considered more appropriate for a warrior-king to avoid it. Afghan chroniclers narrate a particularly relevant anecdote regarding Sher Shah and Humayun that was clearly meant to serve as a character contrast in favour of the former. It involved the capture of the incredibly beautiful daughter of a Raja who had been defeated by Sher Shah's soldiers. "Sher Shah took a look at her and said, 'She is a sure disaster. We shouldn't keep her here. If I keep her here I will be negligent of worldly affairs. Nor is she appropriate for my age. We should send her to Humayun Padshah'. When Humayun Padshah saw her, he did not leave his house for two months".⁴⁰ This episode is perhaps a clear sign of a distrust of female sexuality. But it also highlights the broader motif of unnecessary luxury (involving the obvious objectification of the woman) that Sher Shah had generally denounced. Humayun, unlike Sher Shah, is seen incapable of the personal discipline required of him to avoid the captured woman's beauty and therefore succumbs to a joyous stupor that distracts him from more important responsibilities. This is a matter of sexuality of course but it is also related to a gendered identity involving self-control, prioritising fighting, and acting in a manner commensurate with one's adult years – all qualities required in the male warrior. Humayun, consistent with his image, again fails to fulfill them.

A much clearer expression of these occurs in an episode again involving Sher Shah. Abdullah tells us that once, when Sher Shah was watching a parade of horsemen, a youth appeared who handled his horse excellently provoking the admiration of all. Yet, to the surprise of everyone, Sher Shah set the young man's salary extremely low. When questioned about his strange decision Sher Shah asked the horseman to draw the bow. After several attempts he proved to be completely incapable of handling his weapons. Sher Shah, we are told, explained the apparent paradox in the following way:

Sher Khan said, "This young man knows nothing besides wearing fancy garments and making his horse dance. And he does these things only to screw harlots. He does his riding in their alleys". Shaykh Khalil [who had protested in favour of the young man] remained silent. The paradox

³⁹ Although, as Najmabadi has stated (p. 15), sexual relations between two adult males would be unsuitable.

⁴⁰ Abdullah pp. 123–124.

thus became unravelled when Sher Khan indicated the truth about that young man. Indeed he had always spent his life in loose frivolity (*harzagī*).⁴¹

Here we have a soldier who has all the trappings of a warrior but is in fact something of a fake. He uses his horse (sign of his rank and position) as a means of engaging in frivolous sexuality. He is quite unlike the adult male Sher Shah who not only avoids such distractions, but is a good judge of character and can see right through the young man's sham. When it comes to the real task of a warrior however, i.e. wielding his weapon, the man fails utterly. The parallels between Sher Shah's imposter horseman and the emperor Humayun are quite noteworthy. For he too approaches sex for mere pleasure and is not very keen at fighting (or tolerating hardship). Moreover, here we see the determining quality that makes Humayun's behaviour particularly inappropriate. While Sher Shah's horseman is a young man, thus merely and literally immature (for after all Sher Shah still retains him even if at a lower rank), Humayun is an adult male acting unlike his age. This is the crucial distinction in gender roles, not between effeminate and manly, but between not-yet-man and adult male.

Now, a second aspect of Humayun's flawed sexuality, besides his overemphasis on pleasure, is that even his marriages prove politically unsuccessful or lackluster. In this Humayun and Kamran are complete opposites. Humayun's marriage to Hamida Begam, who later bore the emperor Akbar, is a good example of this. Jawhar, Gulbadan, and Bayazid all tell us that while Humayun was on the run with Sher Shah on his tail, his commanders abandoning him one after another, he reached the environs of Qandahar. At this point, rumours spread that Humayun's last loyal brother Hindal was going to desert him as well – a rumour that much troubled Humayun but was finally proved false after Hindal's arrival. It was against this background that the marriage took place. The story goes that Humayun saw Hamida Begum at a feast and when he expressed interest in her to Hindal, he was met with strong protestations from his brother. Jawhar specifically states that Hindal intended to marry her himself. Humayun, we are told, went ahead with his design and took Hamida Begum to wife, at which point Hindal angrily abandoned his brother.⁴² Now, both Jawhar and Gulbadan, writing years later at the behest of Akbar's ministers, retroactively treated this wedding as a blessed event that led to the emperor's birth, but it is indeed noteworthy that neither author suppressed the political cost of the marriage which would have seemed a glaring error at the time (when hardly anyone could have predicted the creation of a future emperor out of the union). In other words, Jawhar and Gulbadan make it clear that as far as his contemporaries were concerned, even when Humayun pursued sexuality in a manner suitable for an adult male, his marriage had nevertheless failed to serve him well politically. When the ceremonies were being held in 1541, the wedding would have seemed a failure in terms of the politics of sexuality as it led to the further breakup of Humayun's army and the loss of his only supportive brother.

Quite to the contrary, Kamran was remembered as a master of successful manipulation when it came to the politics of sexuality. Not only did Mughal historians write of his ability to isolate Humayun and consolidate his own power through marriage-alliances with various emirs, even some Afghan historians remembered him as a champion of sexual politics. Ahmad Yadgar records an episode from the early years of Babur when a number of disenchanted Lodi

⁴¹ Abdullah pp. 134–135.

⁴² Gulbadan pp. 52–53, Jawhar, p. 31.

emirs come to the Timurid Padshah and invite him to invade India and free the land from the tyrannical yoke of Sultan Ibrahim. The author tells us that the meeting coincided with Kamran's wedding ceremonies which were celebrated with so much pomp that "the Afghans saw the magnificence and audaciousness (*ṣawlat*) of the Mughal government/fortune (*dawlat*) and were quite astounded".⁴³ The feast was concluded, so goes the story, with a good omen suggesting the longevity of Mughal rule in South Asia. Now, while the story bears clear backward projections from the seventeenth century, what is of particular significance here is that it is the marriage of Kamran and not Humayun that is remembered as the symbol of dynastic power and audacity (*ṣawlat*), again reinforcing the image of the former as a male with successful sexuality.

Nor is the sense of aggressiveness in the word "*ṣawlat*" (which can also be translated as ferocity) coincidental. For one gets the impression from the sources that, at least for a male warrior, attaining a wife was sometimes equated with conquest – even if others condemned such predatory acts. What is suggested here is that the correlation of brashness and sexuality for which Kamran is noted in the anecdote above, would raise his esteem in the eyes of some of the warriors for whose service Mughal princes vied so frantically throughout most of the sixteenth century. The following anecdote common to many of the Indo-Persian Afghan histories encapsulates this point. Both Abdullah and Ahmad Yadgar narrate a story in which an Afghan soldier abducts the wife (or beloved) of a merchant (or shepherd) during a campaign. When the man finally finds his wife, she actually rejects him and refuses to go back with him, even going so far as to inform her new husband of their visitor's true intentions. Finally, after a failed attempt by the merchant/shepherd to make off with his wife, the Afghan dies through some twist of fate, and the original pair is reunited.⁴⁴ Perhaps the point of this story was to affirm proper social order, namely, that regardless of her desire, the rightful place of a woman is with her husband or that kidnapping is a deed worthy of reprimand. But clearly these points had to be made with an implicit "in spite of" – viz. Afghan horsemen should not snatch away people's wives *in spite of* the fact that these women prefer the company of their captors. The story, as it is told, presupposes the currency of a viewpoint, perhaps merely a fantasy, that tried to justify stealing women by male warriors. It would be precisely among such men (warriors) that a commander known for his aggressive sexuality would find acceptance and praise. Kamran was remembered to have been such a king, while Humayun cut quite another figure.

It is time to consider the final element of the long anecdote quoted at the beginning of this article narrating the battle between Humayun and his brother Kamran. The reader may recall that, in Bayazid's words, "the Mirza's women and daughters also wrapped turbans around their heads and came out with the men". Ostensibly, this particular detail was meant to give even more credit to Kamran for having won the skirmish even though his troops were numerically inferior and had to resort to including women in their ranks. More deeply still, this aspect of the narrative can be pursued further along two lines: a) transvestitism and b) victory as sexual conquest of women.

⁴³ Ahmad, Yadgar, p. 90.

⁴⁴ Abdullah pp. 24–27, Ahmad Yadgar p. 46.

Not only did the Indo-Persian chronicles of the sixteenth century condone voluntary transvestitism with unflinching consistency (and almost every instance of cross-dressing occurs in a martial context), they actually praised it. For instance, Abdullah reproduces an anecdote regarding the siege of Delhi during the reign of Sultan Bahlul Lodi in which the wife of the Afghan lord Islam Khan “dressed a group of women in men’s clothing and sent them to the battlements” because there were not enough men in the fort.⁴⁵ The transmitter of the report seems to have been quite impressed by the Bibi’s resourcefulness. In the reverse direction, we possess a narrative regarding Sher Shah passing off a group of his warriors as women who after gaining entrance into a fortress felled the guards and opened the gates for the whole army to get in.⁴⁶ Clearly, transgender dressing was considered a praiseworthy act in times of dire need during combat.

Now, on closer inspection, it will become apparent that both examples cited above rest on a common social assumption – viz. it is inappropriate for women to be accosted by men. In the first instance, women dress as warriors in order to prevent the fall of the city and their subsequent capture. In the second case, men pretend to be women, exactly because the male guards are supposed to leave them alone. The defenders fall for this trick and as a result lose their city and their women folk. There is thus an element of irony in both anecdotes, an irony that only makes sense if the capture of an enemy is equated with the conquest of women. The textual evidence amply supports this statement. Conquest is often equated with sexual union between a male (the conqueror) and a female (conquered). This metaphor extends to the linkage between a fortress and the (elite) women residing in it. In such a system, the capture of defeated women was considered almost a right of the victor and shameful only for the captives and their men folk.

That military conquest is expressed in sexual language is perhaps not surprisingly at all. In the sixteenth-century sources one often comes across the expression “to embrace the bride of kingship” in describing the crucial victory of a contender for power. Related to this way of thinking is the equation of women with a fortress or city – the ultimate core, so to speak, for the protection of whom the entire defensive effort would be focused. The example given above regarding the Afghan women who fought during the siege of Delhi already indicates this association. The following anecdote, dated to the early years of the Lodi dynasty, sums up these points quite well but also points out an extra feature – that the status of these women reflected directly on them and their male relatives. Afghan historians report that while the Lodi Sultan Bahlul was away from Delhi in the early years of his reign, the Sharqi Sultan Muhammad along with a Lodi lord named Darya Khan besieged the city.

The inhabitants of Delhi decided to leave the town and its fortress, turn them over to Sultan Mahmud’s people, and depart. A holy man by the name of Shams al-Din took the keys from within the fortress and went to Darya Khan or Mubarak Khan who was one of Mahmud’s high commanders. He said, “I want to beg of you a few things in private”. Darya Khan sent away everybody who was around and said, “What do you have to say?” The sayyid asked him, “What sort of kinship ties connect you to Sultan Mahmud?” Darya Khan answered, “I have no kinship ties with him. I am his servant”. The sayyid spoke a second time, asking “And how is Sultan

⁴⁵ Abdullah p. 13.

⁴⁶ Abdullah p. 124.

Bahlul related to you?” Darya Khan replied, “We are brothers. He is a Lodi and I am a Lodi”. “And what is your connection with his mother and sister?” demanded the sayyid. “His mother is my mother and his sister is my sister,” he answered. Sayyid Shams al-Din took the keys out of his pockets, set them before him and said, “You can protect your mother and sister, or you can expose them. It’s up to you”.

Darya Khan, so goes the story, was ashamed and turned against his master, driving him away from Delhi. What this episode demonstrates is the association of women’s honour with a fortress or town. The capture of the town implies the capture of the elite women who reside therein. Finally, it is the responsibility of the relatives of the potential captives to protect them. The actual right of Sultan Mahmud to take away these women is not contested.

Indeed, in the militarised politics of the mid-sixteenth century in South Asia, the role of warrior kings had particular gendered overtones. Exerting, withstanding, and properly withholding violence were crucial “manly” attributes of leaders. Moreover, control over one’s sexual desires and their channeling into marriage for procreation and alliances were considered vital for such monarchs. Humayun’s portrayal as falling short of meeting the requirements of his role, as often expressed by men in his camp who wrote about the events, might have been either a cause of his unpopularity, or perhaps an effect of his defeat (i.e. later retrojected into the narrative of the events to justify them). In either case, the sources tell us much about particular conceptions of masculinity in the period.

Moreover, the results of the focus on the “gendered aspect” of the conflict between Humayun and Kamran can actually be placed in a broader comparative context regarding the rise of the early modern empires of West Asia. Regardless of how important a role one might ascribe to the function of gunpowder in the formation of the Ottoman, Safavid, and Mughal polities in the sixteenth century (as did Marshall Hodgson), there is little doubt that a significant transition took place in all three domains between the war band in the formative stages of each polity to a bureaucratic absolutist “state” in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. Scholars such as Andrews/Kalpakhli, Babayan and O’Hanlon (cited above) have argued that this transition involved some sort of manipulation of gender and sexuality, in other words, the imposition by the emperor (be he Süleyman the Magnificent, Shah Abbas, or Akbar) of discipline and control on the bodies of men at court. It seems reasonable to suppose that the conflict between Humayun and Kamran in the Mughal Empire signaled in part a disorderly transitional stage away from the war band led by Babur (where as seen above the ruler was expected to lead by example and for the most part follow the same norms of gender roles and sexuality). In essence, Humayun may have been trying to project forward to a separation between the king and his warriors, whereas Kamran (and perhaps Sher Shah) were appealing to the tradition, a status quo that was on the verge of extinction. If so Humayun was not entirely successful particularly as he failed to communicate this transition effectively. Following O’Hanlon, it was left to Akbar to bring about this change successfully.